THE 3RD CO-OPERATIVE MOVEMENT STAKEHOLDERS' ANNUAL CONFERENCE

AND

THE 8TH CUK ANNUAL SCIENTIFIC CONFERENCE 2025

"Co-operatives Build a Better World: Re-energizing the Collective Power of Co-operatives in Africa"

Concept Note

June 2025

1.0 Background and Rationale

Globally, the co-operative movement has historically served as a powerful vehicle for socio-economic empowerment, social justice, and community development. Its business model has grown steadily from the mutual aid societies of the 19th Century to contemporary credit unions (locally known as SACCOs), agricultural co-operatives and modern services worker co-operatives; these institutions have demonstrated remarkable resilience and adaptability in serving communities.

The year 2025 marks a pivotal moment in the history of the co-operative movement globally and African diaspora empowerment, coinciding with the 180th anniversary of the modern co-operative movement and the culmination of the United Nation's First International Decade for People of African Decent (2015 - 2024). This convergence presents an unprecedented opportunity to examine the historical significance, current state, and future potential of African diaspora co-operatives in addressing global challenges.

The fundamental questions that need to be answered include but not limited to: (a) How can we determine the role of co-operatives in addressing contemporary challenges facing African diaspora communities? (b) What are the innovative co-operative business models and their potential applications in various sectors for resilience and adoption? (c) What are the historical revolutions of African and African diaspora co-operatives across different geographical contexts? (d) What kind of actionable frameworks for strengthening co-operative movements in Africa and African Diaspora?

This being the 2025 UN International Year of Co-operatives, the 3rd Co-operative Movement Stakeholders' Annual Conference will be held alongside the 8th CUK Annual Conference to leverage on the pool of rich of stakeholders, policymakers, co-operative practitioners, professional, entrepreneurs, innovators, academia, researchers and students and harness the national networks/ forums for dissemination of the conference findings.

2.0 The Joint Conference 2025 Objectives

The general objective of the Joint Conference 2025 is to examine the role of co-operatives in addressing contemporary challenges facing African and African diaspora communities. Specifically, the key objectives of the event will be to:

a) Document and analyze the historical evolution of the African and African Diaspora co-operatives across different geographical context.
b) Examine the role of co-operatives in addressing contemporary challenges facing African Diaspora communities.
c) Explore innovative co-operative models and their potential applications in various sectors.
d) Foster international collaboration and knowledge exchange among co-operative practitioners, scholars and stakeholders.
e) Develop actionable frameworks for strengthening co-operative movements in the African and the African diaspora

The Joint Conference will therefore gather researchers, practitioners, and industry players, policy makers from National and County Governments, and students to exchange and share knowledge and experience in the areas identified in the sub-themes.

3.0 Expected Outcomes

The following are the expected key outputs from the conference:

a) Linkages and networking among co-operative stakeholders and academia in the co-operative ecosystem locally and internationally.
b) Interventions and re-alignments needed to enable co-operative movement for African and African Diaspora communities as it plays a leading role as catalyst of sustainable development and adaptation.
c) Publication of Joint Conference proceedings.
d) Publication of selected papers in CUK's journals: *African Journal of Co-operative Development and Technology – AJCDT*; and *Journal of Social Sciences, Business and Technology - JSSBT*.
e) Formation of an international network for African and diaspora co-operative scholars and practitioners.
f) Development of policy recommendations for strengthening co-operative movement.
g) Documentation of best practices and successful co-operative model.
h) Creation of a digital repository of African diaspora co-operative history and resources.

4.0 The Joint Conference 2025 Theme

The Joint Conference Theme is: "*Co-operatives Build a Better World: Reenergizing the Collective*

Power of Co-operatives in Africa".

The Joint Conference 2025 is centered on the transformative potential of co-operatives in addressing critical socio-economic and environmental challenges faced by Africa and its Diaspora communities. Aligned with the 2025 UN International Year of Co-operatives, the conference seeks to highlight how co-operatives can serve as vehicles for economic empowerment, social justice, and sustainable community development. By re-energizing the co-operative movement, the conference aims to foster collaboration, innovation, and resilience, ultimately contributing to a more equitable and sustainable world. The central question guiding the conference is: What role can co-operatives play in empowering African and African Diaspora communities to overcome systemic challenges and achieve collective prosperity?

5.0 Description of Sub-themes and Topics

Five (5) sub-themes have been developed to drive the theme:

Sub theme 1: Historical Perspective of the Co-operative Movement

This sub-theme delves into the rich history of co-operatives in Africa and the Diaspora, tracing their origins, evolution, and impact on social and economic development. It examines how co-operatives have been instrumental in fostering solidarity, resilience, and self-reliance among marginalized communities. By understanding the historical context, the conference aims to draw lessons and inspiration for revitalizing the co-operative movement in contemporary times.

Key Issues

- Evaluation of African diaspora co-operatives since the 1840s: Analyzing the growth, challenges, and achievements of co-operatives established by African Diaspora communities.
- Role of co-operatives in civil rights and liberation movements: Exploring how co-operatives have supported struggles for equality, justice, and independence.
- Traditional African co-operatives systems and their modern adaptations: Exploring how co-operatives have supported struggles for equality, justice, and independence.

Sub theme 2: Contemporary Applications

This sub-theme focuses on the current roles and contributions of co-operatives in addressing pressing societal needs. It highlights how co-operatives are empowering communities through innovative solutions in finance, agriculture, housing, healthcare, and education. The sub-theme underscores the adaptability of co-operatives in responding to modern challenges while remaining rooted in principles of solidarity and mutual aid.

Key Issues

- Financial inclusion and co-operative banking: Examining how co-operatives provide access to financial services for underserved populations.
- Agricultural co-operatives and food security: Exploring the role of co-operatives in enhancing agricultural productivity, market access, and food sovereignty.

- Housing co-operatives and community development: Investigating how co-operatives are addressing housing shortages and fostering inclusive urban development.
- Healthcare co-operatives and access to medical services: Analyzing co-operative models that improve healthcare delivery and affordability.
- Educational co-operatives and skill development: Analyzing co-operative models that improve healthcare delivery and affordability.

Sub theme 3: Innovation and Future Directions

This sub-theme explores how co-operatives can harness innovation and emerging trends to remain relevant and impactful in a rapidly changing world. It emphasizes the importance of adopting new technologies, engaging youth, and fostering cross-border collaboration to strengthen the co-operative movement. The sub-theme also calls for supportive policy frameworks to enable co-operatives to thrive.

Key Issues

- Digital technologies in co-operative management: Leveraging digital tools for efficient governance, member engagement, and service delivery.
- Cross-border co-operative networks: Building regional and international partnerships to amplify the impact of co-operatives.
- Youth engagement and co-operative entrepreneurship: Encouraging young people to participate in and lead co-operative initiatives.
- Environmental sustainability initiatives: Promoting eco-friendly practices and green technologies within co-operatives.
- Policy frameworks and enabling environments: Advocating for policies that support the growth and sustainability of co-operatives.

Sub theme 4: The Global Challenges and Co-operative Solutions

This sub-theme addresses how co-operatives can provide innovative and inclusive solutions to global challenges that disproportionately affect African and Diaspora communities. It highlights the unique ability of co-operatives to mobilize collective action and resources to tackle issues such as migration, climate change, inequality, and healthcare access.

Key Issues

- Migration and displacement: Exploring how co-operatives can support migrants and displaced persons through livelihood programs and social integration.
- Climate change adaptation: Investigating co-operative-led initiatives for climate resilience and disaster preparedness.
- Economic inequality: Analyzing how co-operatives can reduce wealth disparities by promoting equitable resource distribution.
- Healthcare access: Highlighting co-operative models that improve access to affordable and quality healthcare services.
- Food sovereignty: Examining how co-operatives can strengthen local food systems and reduce dependency on external markets.

Sub theme 5: Mainstreaming climate change mitigation and adaptations

This sub-theme emphasizes the critical role of co-operatives in promoting climate-friendly practices and sustainable development. It explores how co-operatives can lead the way in mitigating climate change while ensuring food security, biodiversity conservation, and environmental sustainability. The sub-theme also highlights the importance of transitioning to a circular economy and reducing plastic pollution.

Key issues

- Transportation and carbon emissions: Promoting co-operative-led initiatives for sustainable transportation and reduced carbon footprints.
- Climate Friendly Agribusiness: Encouraging agricultural practices that minimize environmental impact and enhance resilience.
- Overall Food Security: Strengthening local food systems through co-operative farming and distribution networks.
- Natural Value of farm Produce: Highlighting the importance of organic and sustainable farming practices.
- Biodiversity of Waterways: Protecting aquatic ecosystems through co-operative conservation efforts.
- Recycling: Promoting waste reduction and recycling initiatives within co-operative frameworks.
- Plastic Pollution: Addressing the plastic waste crisis through co-operative-led campaigns and innovations.
- Clean Energy: Advancing the adoption of renewable energy solutions through co-operatives.
- Waste Management: Developing efficient and sustainable waste management systems.
- Bio Circular Economy: Transitioning to an economic model that prioritizes resource efficiency and sustainability.

6.0 Joint Co-operative Conference 2025 Organization

The organization of the Joint Co-operative Conference 2025 is organized by the State Department for Co-operatives, The Co-operative University of Kenya, and Moshi Co-operative University, Tanzania.

7.0 Joint Conference 2025 Date and Venue

The Joint Conference 2025 will be held for **three full days** on **Tuesday, 22nd July, 2025** to **Thursday, 24th July, 2025**. The venue is **Lake Naivasha Sawela Lodge, Naivasha.**